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02/05/2026

To: Distinguished Teaching Awards Committee, University of California, Los Angeles

Subject: Nomination for Garret May – UCLA Distinguished Teaching Award

Dear Members of the Distinguished Teaching Awards Committee,

It is my pleasure to nominate Mr. Garret May, a current PhD student in the Department of Materials Science and Engineering, for the UCLA Distinguished Teaching Award. I have worked closely with Mr. May for the past two years as the instructor of two courses in which he served as a Teaching Assistant: MSE 130, ‘Phase Relations in Solids’, and MSE 161L, ‘Laboratory in Ceramics’. This experience provides me with a strong basis on which to recommend him based on both his demonstrated excellence and his exceptional potential as an educator.

Throughout this time, Mr. May has consistently proven himself to be an extraordinarily hardworking, intelligent, and dedicated Teaching Assistant with a genuine passion for teaching and for supporting students in achieving their academic goals. He has played an active role in improving course content and laboratory experiments, and his positive attitude and strong analytical skills have frequently provided valuable insight from a student’s perspective. He is unfailingly kind, respectful, and professional, with excellent interpersonal skills that foster a supportive and inclusive learning environment.

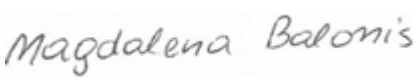
Mr. May is highly approachable and responsive, and students have repeatedly commented on his flexibility and willingness to provide clarification and assistance. He is deeply invested in the learning process, responding promptly to student inquiries and routinely offering additional meetings outside of scheduled discussion sections and office hours. During discussion sessions, he effectively reinforced course material by thoughtfully recapping lecture content, thereby strengthening student understanding.

In addition, Mr. May has actively advocated for student rights, mental health, and inclusion, values that are strongly upheld within our department. He possesses a strong moral compass, communicates effectively, and consistently goes above and beyond his assigned responsibilities to ensure that all students remain engaged and supported. By sharing his own experiences as a UCLA undergraduate, he established a strong sense of connection and trust with students. His teaching evaluations were consistently outstanding, exceeding 8 on 9 scale, reflecting his effectiveness and dedication as an educator. Beyond his teaching duties, he also contributed to fundraising efforts and assisted in the acquisition of new equipment for our undergraduate teaching laboratory.

For these reasons, I offer my strongest support for Mr. May's nomination for the UCLA Distinguished Teaching Award. He is a highly motivated and deserving Teaching Assistant with tremendous promise, and this recognition would further encourage his development as an outstanding scholar and educator. Given his empathy, patience, engagement, and insight, I am confident that he has a bright future in academia and aspires to become a professor himself.

Please do not hesitate to contact me should you require any additional information regarding this nomination.

Sincerely,



Magdalena Balonis, Ph.D

Assistant Adjunct Professor

Department of Materials Science and Engineering, University of California Los Angeles

Phone: (310)-825-3539, Email: mbalonis@ucla.edu

Garret May - Teaching Accomplishment Statement

I think one of my greatest strengths as a TA is the collection of supplementary materials I bring to complement existing course content. For both C&EE courses I have TA'd for, I have created new rubrics for all of the assignments to better communicate expectations with students. Through my participation in CUTF, I have been exposed to different kinds of rubrics for writing assessment, and have recently switched to formative rubrics to better support student growth. This rubric works well because while I keep the overall rubric the same, the weighting of different components shifts through the writing process. Where the topic would weigh more for an annotated bibliography, the argument will weigh more for the draft. I then use different "conversion formulas" along the process, so that while my comments and the rubric score may be the same, the final letter grade of the assignment is more lenient in earlier stages of writing (#5). This was accompanied by a new peer review worksheet (#3) so that students can actually assess each other the same way I would (graded sample in #4). This has dramatically improved the comments I have seen students give each other, moving from grammar and mechanical notes to overarching critiques of argument development and completeness of content.

One specific accommodation strategy I have implemented in my classes is the use of separated homework modules. What this does is allow me to restrict access to homework solutions until after the assignment itself has been submitted; in practice, this means I can now offer longer extensions for students without preventing other students from accessing materials they may need to study and review (#2). I have been able to share these strategies, slides, and rubrics with other TA's in my department in order to improve materials in other classes as well. The student response I get from these teaching strategies makes all the extra effort worth it (#1).

My biggest effort currently (and one of my proudest accomplishments of graduate school) is in the development of a new curriculum for my department in the form of an environmental justice ethics class. I sat on a committee five years ago to advocate for changing the way engineering ethics was taught, which resulted in an effort to split the class (previously one for all of engineering) into discipline specific courses, allowing for greater specificity in case studies and instruction. There were no faculty members in my department willing to take on the task, so I volunteered to be the one to design the course as a part of the collegium of university teaching fellows. Sustainability was the whole reason I chose this major, and yet I had no opportunity to take classes about the environment; I am so excited to get to bring an environmental justice ethics class to my department so that students after me can have the opportunity I wish I had. A preliminary interest form sent out to the undergraduate students received 60 responses, more than a third of the entire major. This shows that my class will not only meet the learning and course goals of the university, but also connect to the interests of the students themselves. This course aims to connect engineers to the human impact of our work instead of only staying isolated within the realm of scientific novelty, which is a primary goal of my teaching. This comes together as the accumulation of all of the teaching, administrative, and advocacy work I have been doing since I arrived at UCLA in 2018. I plan to apply to make the

course a full Materials Science course again next year to hopefully teach a second cohort of students and to teach those who were unable to enroll this year due to demand.

This past year, I was able to work with Dr. Balonis to secure a donation to purchase new equipment. This involved a survey of current and recent students, teaching assistants, and faculty members to see what upgrades to our teaching lab would be the most beneficial to the student experience. I then worked with the development team within the School of Engineering to draft a proposal and itemized list to the donors, resulting in a gift of $50,000. This allowed the purchase of several new pieces of equipment. I have been able to use two of these new machines to help with the capstone projects of more than 25 students and the student-run E1 class from our department.

Garret May - Teaching Philosophy Statement

Thermodynamics has a reputation as one of the most difficult courses in engineering: that belief is a self-fulfilling prophecy. There is a myth—inside and out of STEM—that successful students are "naturally gifted." I strive to get rid of that idea; all students deserve to feel capable of success. When students enter class thinking it is too hard for them, they are more likely to give up from lack of motivation. Struggling with material the first time is just a matter of learning, not an indication of failure. My teaching philosophy has been driven by one single tenet: to never forget my experiences as an undergraduate student who was struggling. I will always be honest with my students about my own educational challenges; this includes explaining that my relationship with thermodynamics had a rocky start. During my undergrad at UCLA, my first exposure to the material ended with me scoring more than three standard deviations below average on the midterm. By demonstrating that I am not a mythical genius, but rather a lifelong learner, I hope to inspire students to see themselves mastering the material as I have.

To prepare my students for success, I invest time in the first session to lay the groundwork for a safe learning environment: I introduce my teaching philosophy, explain some of my own learning struggles, and foster open communication. Creating a safe classroom involves cultivating an environment where students are not afraid to fail or get something wrong. I do this by reminding students I do not believe in "stupid questions," and am willing to explain a concept in different ways to match their learning needs. Sometimes, when I introduce a practice problem, I am met with nothing but blank stares and confusion. When this happens, I perform a "temperature check" on my students, where I state each concept covered in the problem and have them respond on a thumbs-up to thumbs-down scale. This allows me to determine the source of confusion and focus on that—even if it means throwing away my original lesson plans. I also utilize active learning solutions, including group work and inviting volunteers to solve problems at the board, to effectively engage students and allow them to articulate their thought processes. All practice problems in class are done in small groups; once students can explain a concept to someone else, it means they have mastered it. This also allows me to walk through the classroom to answer questions that students may not feel comfortable asking to the whole group, as well as seeing if there are any misunderstandings amongst many of the students that are best addressed to the whole class. One change I made recently in my review sessions where I had volunteers do work on the board was to not only make corrections, but actually grade the work for the class. This increased transparency between me and the students in that they better understood how to demonstrate their own understanding, which can be more difficult when drawing diagrams instead of solving a more traditional math problem.

My commitment to my students can be distinguished by one factor: I do the homework. I support my students by creating all of my own answer keys for the homework and exams, and developing a "Helpful Hints" section for each homework which assists students in the most difficult parts of the assignment. This practice extends to exams as well. I gauge the difficulty of the exam by the time it takes me—if I cannot complete it in less than half the time given to

students, then it needs to be reworked. This also informs what content I prepare for review sessions before each test. Within lab classes, I promote success by providing sample work, specific rubrics, and detailed comments when grading (#4); this prevents students from losing points on trivial errors so they can concentrate on enhancing their writing skills. As I work towards my graduate certificate in writing pedagogy, my teaching of writing has changed significantly. I now incorporate more metacognitive teaching, explicitly drawing connections between writing assignments and the non-writing skills that the assignment is helping students to develop. My previous instruction only used writing to communicate, but now I also utilize writing to learn. This has been especially helpful in my discussion based transportation sustainability course. Having a small free write before discussion around a specific question allows students to formulate their own thoughts, and provide something to look at for students who may be more hesitant to contribute to classroom discussions. I also encourage students to connect class concepts to their own work outside of the classroom. This has proved useful in bringing new and interesting perspectives, and driving student engagement.

In addition to direct teaching strategies, I also try to improve the experience of my students through changes in extensions and accommodations. No matter how amazing a classroom environment is, all students are people first; sometimes outside circumstances will affect their ability to spend time and energy on a class. I try to mitigate this with a "no-questions-asked" extension policy. Any student in crisis should not have to write an entire essay just to ask for an extension, and I have found it reduces stress for all students to work this way. I have spoken at faculty meetings about my own experiences with extensions and complications with our disability office to advocate for departmental policies that better support all of our students. I have successfully improved access to hybrid learning, pushed for more lenient extension policies from other faculty, and ensured PhD students can use their accommodations for the oral preliminary exam.

I want to teach a new generation of engineers who are not shamed into learning but instead driven by curiosity, support, and a desire to do good. The experiences I have had through my education shape the educator I want to become. I want to be transparent with struggles, and incorporate activism into the classroom to make my students feel comfortable and seen.

CEE C183/C283: Fall 2025

Garrett was an incredible TA. He was very knowledgeable about not only the material but also writing structures for the assignments in this class. He helped the discussion facilitators gain interaction from the audience when the discussion was low, which was very helpful as well. Overall, I thought Garrett was both a wonderful person and a wonderful TA. All assignments were graded with a ton of helpful feedback in a very efficient timeframe. Honestly, the best TA I have had thus far at UCLA.

MSE 130: Fall 2025

I had Garret as a TA for MatSci 104 in the summer online and he was already an AMAZING TA, but having him in person is a million times better. Garret is one of the first TAs to actually know my name without ever really seeking help outside of class and I personally feel that says a lot already. He always had a great passion in discussion as he was always prepared and organized. I believe that his authenticity and experience with this course as a TA and even as a student elevated the experience, as his genuineness and passion about the subject and teaching was reflected during these discussion sections. Although I only went to office hours once during week 10, I loved the group format as sometimes one on one office hours can be intimidating. Garret was always understanding and easy to reach and get help from as he was always willing to help outside of normal class time. I do regret not going earlier or more often as it was truly an amazing experience and opportunity. Garret's biggest strength was not only just incorporating content from lecture into section, but being able to expand on these topics efficiently. I never once felt lost in his discussion as it was very organized and straightforward. I believe that was possible because of the format of his section. In section he expanded on the topic and followed it with a relevant example or practice problem. This format was so beneficial for me especially as a student who learns through examples as it allowed for further expansion on lecture that felt relevant and not unnecessary as it feels a lot of other times in different classes. Garret was always able to explain these topics so easily in a comprehensible way that made learning the material easier and gave me an overall better experience. In my most honest opinion, I do not think Garret has any weaknesses solely because his discussion section and teaching style was so efficient for me. I believe the best way to put how I feel towards Garret's teaching would be the following, " If Garret May's teaching has a million fans, then I am one of them. If Garret May's teaching has ten fans, then I am one of them. If Garret May's teaching has only one fan then that is me. If Garret May's teaching has no fans, then that means I am no longer on earth. " I truly believe that Garret is by far one of the best TAs that I have had at my time here at UCLA.

Probably the best T.A I have ever had. Great at explaining concepts in easily digestible ways supplemented by practice problems and homeworks. During discussions he would go around making sure that every single person understood what was going on and the content that was being discussed. Very open after class in office hours and quick to respond to emails with detailed answers.

Discussion sections were always highly relevant to the course and the exams, and provided a good balance between lecture and practice problems. Garret maintained good communication with the instructor and the students, such that the course expectations were always clear. I was very comfortable asking questions and approaching him for any reason, and he never failed to explain a topic I was confused about. Beyond being very adept at explaining course material, Garret is knowledgeable about administrative processes, course planning, campus resources, and more. He is eager to give advice and engage in meaningful conversations with students. Garret is evidently very passionate about teaching, and he has a gift for it. Overall, Garret is an exceptional TA. Other TAs, as well as professors, would benefit from following his example.

Garret is the actual GOAT. I can say with much certainty he is the best TA I have had at UCLA and it's not even a competition. Unrivaled in knowledge, passion, and relatability, he truly made thermodynamics not only tolerable, but enjoyable. He should be put on the shortlist for TA of the year, I cannot speak highly enough of him and his qualifications. 10/10 would take this class again if Garret was my TA.

Garret is amazing. Deeply concerned with student learning, he gets straight to the point, teaching the most important concepts and giving space for student questions and feedback. He said in the first discussion section that he was going to make every Friday worth our time, and he did just that. I always feel supported and seen whenever he is around, and I hope to get the privilege of having more TAs/instructors like him.

Garret is THE BEST teaching assistant I've had. I feel so comfortable asking for help because he is very honest about what we should expect from this class. He sets very realistic expectations because he was an undergrad student like us. His discussion sessions are very organized with slides, recapping the week of learning, which really helped with my personal learning. During lecture, content would oftentimes overwhelm me but because Garret is well prepared and knowledgable of necessary content, I understand it by the end of discussion. Overall, he is so supportive and encouraging with our learning and has made 130 one of my favorite MSE classes!

MSE 130: Fall 2024

- Garret is an amazing TA. He is very kind, approachable, and enthusiastic about the course material, and I always felt welcome asking questions in discussion and office hours. Garret excels at explaining complex concepts in a simple and clear manner. He is very supportive of his students and truly cares about our learning and well-being. He is accommodating, often extends his office hours, and holds extra review sessions before exams. His discussion section ties in nicely with the content covered in lectures, and I really enjoyed the format of working on practice problems and then walking through them as a class.
- Garret is hands down the best TA I have ever had, and I say this as a senior who is close to graduating. His office hours are more helpful than many lectures I've been to in other courses, and I learn more during his discussions than I ever had in any other discussion. He is amazingly talented into distilling content to the key ideas, presenting them clearly, and helping us apply them. He has an amazing ability to anticipate what students will be confused on before we even know what to ask, and he addresses our questions immediately so that we can move on to more challenging problems. He also has amazing interpersonal skills - he's extremely approachable and easy to talk to while still being an expert, and he's able to level with us without ever being condescending. Best TA ever!!!

- Overall, I think Garret was one of the best TAs I've had so far. It was clear that he cared about helping us understand the material and I liked how approachable he was. I think part of the reason why he was so approachable was because he sounded like he understood what we were going through as students. During discussions, he would identify that we didn't know what was going on and then help us from there instead of just giving us work to do. I also liked how he was very down to earth and didn't teach us anything unnecessary. So to conclude, I think Garret is a great TA and he genuinely helped me understand the course concepts better.
- The best TA I've ever taken a class with. So engaging and helpful during discussions, and its really obvious how much he cares about students learning rather than just memorising the material. Goes above and beyond to make sure he attends to students needs, and the homeworks and midterm were graded so incredibly fast. There were no weaknesses, Garret made me feel like I did not need to stress out for this class as I was in good hands.
- This TA brought great energy to class and always went slowly over topics, taking questions, elaborating on concepts, etc.. The discussion slides were always a great recap of the lecture, helpful hints about homework, and practice problems that helped me apply skills that help general understanding. The TA also helped prepare for exams by taking time to do review sessions that outlined things to do to prepare, answering any lasting general questions about the material, and went over homework assignments. Plus, his fits were always rad. Thank you !! Literally no suggestions on improvements. He helped create a great learning environment, let people talk but asked for quiet when going over important topics and never made me feel like I had a stupid question.

MSE 130: Fall 2023

- Garret is an excellent TA who clearly puts in the effort to make discussion sections valuable for students. We students also appreciate his quick turnaround on grading. He has a very good understanding of the material and teaches it well, sharing with us his own experiences with taking the class. Overall, the discussions were worth going to and Garret did a great job.
- Garrett was an amazing TA and truly cared about how we engaged with the materials. His review sessions before exams were informative and succinctly summarized material from the course. I also felt that he made discussions engaging and created a space where we could feel comfortable with asking questions.
- The TA was very open and approachable. He made it so easy to ask questions both in class and after hours. Even when the content didn't make sense, he had a great pulse on the class and would change/ stop the lecture to build up that foundation. Garret made an environment where students could be honest with their level in learning.

MSE 104: Summer 2025

- Garrett would sometimes lecture in place of Professor Goorsky, and his lecturers were always very enthusiastic and engaging. I felt that he was very aware of the fact that this was a fast paced course, and tried to really engage with students to make sure we were understanding the material.

MSE 161L: Spring 2025

- Garret is amzing and has been so helpful this quarter. I had a very difficult quarter with tryign to figure out my post grad plans but he's been incredibly helpful which I am extremely grateful for. Garret always cares about student learning and does his best to improve our abilities by giving critical but helpful feedback on lab reports and presentations. Thank you Garret!
- Garret is one of the best TAs I have had at UCLA. His acumen is only paralleled by his organization, grace, and kindness. He is also knowledgable with tech, which makes our Canvas page very neat.

MSE 161L: Spring 2024

- Garret is one of the best TAs I have ever had in my classes. He has TA'ed for me before. When he is my TA, I feel confident that I will do well in the class. He always makes students feel comfortable, he never judges anyone for asking even the simplest questions, and he wants us to succeed. He will go out of his way to make sure his students can complete their work and is extremely responsive to emails. This makes him approachable and easy to ask questions to.

MSE 161L: Spring 2023

- Garret was an excellent TA all around! He was helpful and accessible during sections, and his feedback on lab reports was always clearly worded and fair. He was a great addition to an already excellent class.

MSE 131L: Winter 2025

- Garret is an amazing TA! He is very kind and approachable, and I always felt welcome asking questions during and outside of class. He excels at explaining difficult concepts in a simple and clear manner. He is truly supportive of his students and genuinely cares about our learning and well-being.
- It shows in class how much effort Garret puts into preparing slides for the class and organizing it so that it is easy to understand for us students. His cheerfulness always brightens up the lab even when our experiments fail and we have to stay longer. He is always willing to help and even explain multiple times until we understand what is going on. Garret is a patient and all-around awesome TA!

MSE 131L: Winter 2024

- Very clear and communicative. Open to suggestions and well received to suggestions for change, Answered questions promptly, and was accommodating for students. Knowledgable about the subject and the material we have on the subject.

Collapse All | View Progress

Homework

Complete All Items

- Homework 1
  Jul 10, 2025 160 pts
- Homework 2
  Jul 21, 2025 80 pts
- Homework 3
  Aug 17, 2025 120 pts Submit

Homework 4

Complete All Items

- Homework 4
  Aug 19, 2025 140 pts Submit

Exams

Complete One Item

- Quiz 1
  100 pts
- Midterm 1
  100 pts
- Quiz 2
  100 pts Submit
- Quiz 2 Makeup
  100 pts Submit

Solutions

- MSE 104 HW 1 Solutions - EP.pdf
- MSE 104 HW 2 Solutions.pdf
- MSE 104 Quiz 1 Solutions 2025.pdf
- MSE 104 Midterm Solutions 2025.pdf

Recent Homework Solutions

Prerequisites: Homework

- MSE 104 HW 3 Solutions.pdf

Homework 4 Solutions

Prerequisites: Homework 4

- MSE 104 HW 4 Solutions.pdf

Quiz Solutions

Prerequisites: Exams

- MSE 104 Quiz 2 Solutions.pdf

Peer Review Guide

Reviewer Name: _____ Author Name: _____

Paper Title: _____

Instructions: Read your partner's paper, marking and taking notes appropriately, then box the score within each section, and explain your score in the comments section below. Emphasis should be on the content of the writing, arguments constructed, and ethical analysis more than just grammar

	5: Exceeded expectations	4: Met expectations	3: Shy of expectations	2: Did not meet expectations	1: Significantly below expectations
Topic	The topic is specific, relevant, nuanced, and has interesting perspective	The topic is specific, relevant, and nuanced	The topic is relevant but lacks sufficient depth or specificity, or already discussed in class	The topic is not relevant to the class	No clear topic
Comments:					
Sustainability	Connection to sustainability is clear, strong, and present throughout entire paper	Explicit connections to sustainability, covered in appropriate depth	Connection to sustainability is there, but lacks sufficient depth or completeness	Connection to sustainability is barely present	Did not address connection to sustainability at all
Comments:					
Equity	Connection to equity is clear, strong, and present throughout entire paper	Explicit connections to equity, covered in appropriate depth	Connection to equity is there, but lacks sufficient depth or completeness	Connection to equity is barely present	Did not address connection to equity at all
Comments:					

	5: Exceeded expectations	4: Met expectations	3: Shy of expectations	2: Did not meet expectations	1: Significantly below expectations
Ethics	Includes at least two ethical frameworks for analysis, and puts them in tension; used to explore arguments and counterarguments	Includes at least two ethical frameworks for analysis and compares them	Includes one ethical framework for analysis well	One ethical framework is briefly introduced, lacking depth or completeness	Did not address ethical frameworks at all
Comments:					
Argument	Argument is original, claims are strong and cohesive, and easy for the reader to follow	Argument is original and supported by appropriate claims	Argument is supported by appropriate claims, but does not expand beyond what was already discussed in class	Argument lacked clarity or was unsupported by appropriate claims	No argument was made and lacked supporting evidence for claims
Comments:					
Research and Citations	Citations from various source types, cited appropriately, synthesized in a new and interesting way	Enough peer reviewed citations, cited appropriately	Evidence is appropriate, but not enough peer reviewed citations	Significantly lacking appropriate evidence or citations, no in text citations	No appropriate evidence or citations
Comments:					
Writing	Few grammatical errors, syntactically or stylistically interesting with varied sentence structure	Few grammatical errors, does not detract from readability	Grammatical or formatting errors begin to detract from the quality or readability of the paper	Grammatical or formatting errors significantly detract from the quality or readability of the paper	Paper is almost unreadable due to grammatical or formatting errors
Comments:					

93

View Rubric

Annotated Bibliography

Criteria	Ratings
Topic	**Exceeded Expectations** The topic is specific, relevant, nuanced, and has interesting perspective **Comments** I am seriously impressed by this! I can see how much effort went into it Perhaps workshop a more interesting title though 10 / 10 pts
Sustainability	**Shy of Expectations** Connection to sustainability is there, but lacks sufficient depth or completeness **Comments** Expanding on the idea of a 15 minute city, or even incorporating emissions data would strengthen this part of the argument, and give additional support to the need for accessible public transit 3 / 5 pts
Equity	**Exceeded Expectations** Connection to equity is clear, strong, and present throughout entire paper **Comments** Truly great job on this, it was present through the whole thing and you explored lots of different angles 5 / 5 pts
Ethics	**Met Expectations** Includes at least two ethical frameworks for analysis and compares them **Comments** Included ethical analysis, will just need some more for the draft (making it its own section would be an easy way to do this) 8 / 10 pts
Argument	**Shy of Expectations** Argument is supported by appropriate claims, but does not expand beyond what was already discussed in class **Comments** Your research is incredible, but the breadth of work you have included makes it a bit harder to follow your argument. It's totally possible you could do this once you have a draft though, just be mindful of how far you are straying from your main points and arguments 3 / 5 pts
Research and Citations	**Exceeded Expectations** Citations from various source types, cited appropriately, synthesized in a new and interesting way **Comments** Awesome job!! The only thing I would advise is to have some strategy to handle that your sources have a very wide geographic spread, so ensuring that comparison between them is done accurately will be very important. 10 / 10 pts
Writing	**Met Expectations** Few grammatical errors, does not detract from readability 4 / 5 pts

Total Points: 43

overarching general public, similarly to "groupthinking," in which one method or determination is prioritized simply because it fits the majority.

I like this source because it examines specific parts of alternative transportation methods, in this case rideshare services. It pushes the idea that rideshare applications, while promoting accessibility and convenience, only serve the popular public as opposed to considering all types of people (i.e., including riders with disabilities or impairments). In its negative outlook on rideshare services, it sides with the idea that public transportation would be the supreme leader of promoting accessibility. It in turn pushes that responsibility on government bodies instead of other groups such as corporations or individual drivers who have limited liability or training for disabled riders.

How a Transit App for the Blind Could Revolutionize How Everyone Rides — Streetsblog USA. https://usa.streetsblog.org/2022/07/21/how-a-transit-app-for-the-blind-could-revolutionize-how-everyone-rides. Accessed 26 Jan. 2026.

This source discusses the implications of Waymap, a navigation-focused application that was introduced to help people with United States transit systems. The article discusses the functions of the app, two of the most prominent being a) its ability to locate users even three feet underground (where GPS signals don't traditionally function) and give turn-by-turn audio-based directions and b) its accessible route customization via preferences such as walking speeds and avoiding stairs. The software pushes ethical principles of equity by giving everyone equal, free access to the application to utilize transportation effectively.

This source uniquely gives a supplement to public transportation by leveling the playing field and giving those with impairments or disabilities a much easier time navigating. The Washington Metropolitan Area Transit Authority began piloting the application and Metro is looking into similar methods, showing organizational trust in the application and also displaying how organizations can use similar methods to achieve equitable justice for transportation accessibility. In addition, it can disprove the common attitude that changing transportation to be more accessible would worsen conditions for the general public as anyone would find easier navigation to be quite helpful.

International Transport Forum. The Economic Benefits of Improved Accessibility to Transport Systems. ITF Roundtable Reports No. 165, OECD Publishing, 2017, https://www.itf-oecd.org/sites/default/files/docs/economic-benefits-improved-accessibility-transport-systems.pdf

This source dives into well-developed detail on numerous benefits of accessible transportation. Primary notes include: economic benefits outweigh the investment cost, accessibility benefits support everyone and not just disabled users, and benefits extend to users, non-users, operators, and more impacts to broad bodies such as the public sector and employment. In addition to explaining the benefits of accessible transportation, this source,

Part A: Policy and Practice, vol. 203, Jan. 2026, p. 104729. *ScienceDirect*, https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tra.2025.104729.

This source discusses the Multi-Dimensional, High-Granularity (MDHG) Transportation Equity Index, an alternative approach to assess transportation equity. This approach is unique in that it examines accessibility, service quality, and population needs in conjunction. This is in contrast to the traditional equity approach which focuses only on how accessible destinations are in terms of distance or travel time. The MDHG index takes accessibility, reliability, and demographic into consideration by combining those statistics in one measurement to allow planners to determine which areas can be improved in terms of service quality and physical accessibility. An approach such as MDHG is more equitable due to its ability to see past initial circumstances. For example, neighborhoods that are geographically connected but are challenged by low-quality transit may be skipped under more traditional analyses.

I plan on comparing this method to the Overall Topological Accessibility Index (OTAI) (from *Overall Topological Accessibility Index (OTAI): A Proposed Indicator of Urban Transportation Accessibility*) as an accessibility indicator. The main objective of this would be to present how emerging technologies would help improve accessible transportation. It also serves to counter the counterargument that implementing sustainable transportation in rural communities would be either too hard of a task for governing agencies or too expensive by making it easier for planners to identify areas with weak transportation infrastructure.

Minuyee, Mahnoush, et al. "The Impact of Transportation Equity on Healthcare Accessibility for Children with Asthma." *Transportation Research Interdisciplinary Perspectives*, vol. 33, Sept. 2025, p. 101616. *ScienceDirect*, https://doi.org/10.1016/j.trip.2025.101616.

This source, similar to some of the aforementioned sources, examines the accessibility of transportation methods on behalf of a disadvantaged population. In this case, it examines how children with asthma feel about the accessibility of different transportation modes when it comes to connecting them with healthcare, and highlights the discrepancies between well-developed and lesser-developed communities. The study uses 18,393 hospital visits from Calgary, Canada to conclude that private vehicles are most reliable, while public transit and taxis often fail to meet emergency needs, especially at night time. This is relevant to my paper as it proposes the inequity faced by impaired demographics when it comes to healthcare accessibility.

This source is similar to "*Can Public Transportation Improve Equity in High-Level Healthcare Time Accessibility?*" in that it analyzes how accessible transportation translates to accessible healthcare. In addition, it considers temporal data (i.e., challenges faced at night time) to conclude that our public transportation infrastructure is simply not enough in terms of its ability to accommodate disadvantaged groups. This entry supports the idea that if policymakers are to consider transportation and healthcare successfully, they could

with previous sources on emerging technology to make public transportation more appealing to community members.

This source discusses direct countermeasures against the notion that public transportation is unsafe. Using this information with "*Bridging the Gap: Understanding Rural Commuting Patterns and Transportation Choices*" could address the inequalities in attitudes of certain demographics on public transportation services, such as how older people and women were found to be less likely to utilize public transportation. Making transportation more safe by using the aforementioned security measures could help normalize public transportation to create a more equitable environment.

Zhao, Ying, et al. "Linking Accessibility, Transportation Satisfaction, and Destination Satisfaction: Evidence from a Ten-Year Longitudinal Study in Xishuangbanna, China." *Travel Behaviour and Society*, vol. 42, Jan. 2026, p. 101130. *ScienceDirect*, https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tbs.2025.101130.

This study examines travel attitudes over ten-years in Xishuangbanna, China. It considers how easy it is for users to reach important destinations, attractions, or facilities, and how that translates into transportation and destination satisfaction. It connects experiences with accessible measures with destination satisfaction and puts forward the framework that having accessible, safe transportation results in a more positive outlook for tourists during their trips. It establishes that planners and policymakers should consider travel time (objective measures) and user satisfaction (subjective responses) when designing transportation infrastructure.

This study is unique in that it centers around the attitudes of tourists in the lens of transportation design. While the source doesn't directly tackle an ethical matter, I believe this point of view could be important in establishing why it is important to have accessible transportation in the first place. It also provides an additional perspective to the uses of accessible transportation that extend beyond community members' usage only; prioritizing safe and friendly transportation design may also attract tourism thus expanding the economy and proving that accessible transportation is worth the cost. It could be used in conjunction with other sources to address the counterargument that money is the main preventative force in designing accessible transportation.

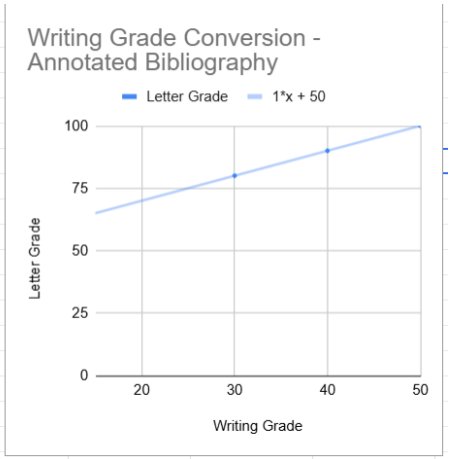
Annotated Bibliography

You've already rated students with this rubric. Any major changes could affect their assessment results.

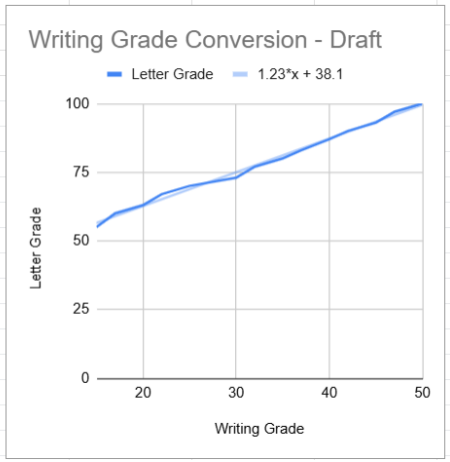
Criteria	Ratings					Pts
Topic	**10 pts** **Exceeded Expectations** The topic is specific, relevant, nuanced, and has interesting perspective	**8 pts** **Met Expectations** The topic is specific, relevant, and nuanced	**6 pts** **Shy of Expectations** The topic is relevant but lacks sufficient depth or specificity, or already discussed in class	**4 pts** **Did Not Meet Expectations** The topic is not relevant to the class	**2 pts** **Significantly Below Expectations** No clear topic	10 pts
Sustainability	**5 pts** **Exceeded Expectations** Connection to sustainability is clear, strong, and present throughout entire paper	**4 pts** **Met Expectations** Explicit connections to sustainability, covered in appropriate depth	**3 pts** **Shy of Expectations** Connection to sustainability is there, but lacks sufficient depth or completeness	**2 pts** **Did Not Meet Expectations** Connection to sustainability is barely present	**1 pts** **Significantly Below Expectations** Did not address connection to sustainability at all	5 pts
Equity	**5 pts** **Exceeded Expectations** Connection to equity is clear, strong, and present throughout entire paper	**4 pts** **Met Expectations** Explicit connections to equity, covered in appropriate depth	**3 pts** **Shy of Expectations** Connection to equity is there, but lacks sufficient depth or completeness	**2 pts** **Did Not Meet Expectations** Connection to equity is barely present	**1 pts** **Significantly Below Expectations** Did not address connection to equity at all	5 pts
Ethics	**10 pts** **Exceeded Expectations** Includes at least two ethical frameworks for analysis, and puts them in tension; they are used to explore arguments and counterarguments	**8 pts** **Met Expectations** Includes at least two ethical frameworks for analysis and compares them	**6 pts** **Shy of Expectations** Includes one ethical framework for analysis well	**4 pts** **Did Not Meet Expectations** One ethical framework is briefly introduced, lacking depth or completeness	**2 pts** **Significantly Below Expectations** Did not address ethical frameworks at all	10 pts
Argument	**5 pts** **Exceeded Expectations** Argument is original, claims are strong and cohesive, and easy for the reader to follow	**4 pts** **Met Expectations** Argument is original and supported by appropriate claims	**3 pts** **Shy of Expectations** Argument is supported by appropriate claims, but does not expand beyond what was already discussed in class	**2 pts** **Did Not Meet Expectations** Argument lacked clarity or was unsupported by appropriate claims	**1 pts** **Significantly Below Expectations** No argument was made and lacked supporting evidence for claims	5 pts
Research and Citations	**10 pts** **Exceeded Expectations** Citations from various source types, cited appropriately, synthesized in a new and interesting way	**8 pts** **Met Expectations** Enough peer reviewed citations, cited appropriately	**6 pts** **Shy of Expectations** Evidence is appropriate, but not enough peer reviewed citations	**4 pts** **Did Not Meet Expectations** Significantly lacking appropriate evidence or citations, no in text citations	**2 pts** **Significantly Below Expectations** No appropriate evidence or citations	10 pts
Writing	**5 pts** **Exceeded Expectations** Few grammatical errors, syntactically or stylistically interesting with varied sentence structure	**4 pts** **Met Expectations** Few grammatical errors, does not detract from readability	**3 pts** **Shy of Expectations** Grammatical or formatting errors begin to detract from the quality or readability of the paper	**2 pts** **Did Not Meet Expectations** Grammatical or formatting errors significantly detract from the quality or readability of the paper	**1 pts** **Significantly Below Expectations** Paper is almost unreadable due to grammatical or formatting errors	5 pts

Total Points: 50

Writing Grade	Letter Grade
15	
17	
20	
22	
25	
30	80
32	
35	
37	
40	90
42	
45	
47	
50	100



Writing Grade	Letter Grade
15	55
17	60
20	63
22	67
25	70
30	73
32	77
35	80
37	83
40	87
42	90
45	93
47	97
50	100



Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

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UCLA Samueli School of Engineering

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13 February 2026

Dear Members of the Review Committee:

I am delighted to support Garret May's nomination for the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award. I have had the pleasure of working with him in multiple capacities: he took my Transportation Sustainability course in Winter 2025, served as the TA for that course in Fall 2025, and is currently one of my TAs for the Ethics in Civil and Environmental Engineering course in Winter 2026. I also serve as his Faculty Mentor for his participation in the Collegium of University Teaching Fellows (CUTF), where he is developing the new Materials Science and Engineering course, Climate and Energy Technology: Creating Environmental Justice Frameworks, drawing inspiration from my Ethics and Environmental Justice courses.

Garret has consistently demonstrated exceptional teaching skill, professionalism, and dedication to student success. In both Transportation Sustainability and Ethics, he thoughtfully updated and refined rubrics to better scaffold student writing, critical analysis, and technical communication. These updates provided transparent expectations and structured feedback, supporting equitable assessment and helping students improve clarity, argumentation, and synthesis of complex material. His grading is consistently thorough, thoughtful, and responsive, giving students actionable guidance and reinforcing learning objectives. Students regularly highlight that his feedback is insightful, motivating, and enhances their ability to communicate complex ideas effectively.

Garret's teaching exemplifies student-centered, inclusive, and justice-centered pedagogy. He facilitates discussion, encourages diverse perspectives, and employs active-learning strategies that challenge students while supporting their engagement and confidence. In both courses, he leads discussions that foster a collaborative learning environment, empowering students from varied backgrounds to participate meaningfully and develop their analytical and ethical reasoning skills.

Of particular note is his work developing the MSE course through CUTF. This justice-centered course engages students in analyzing climate and energy technologies, understanding their societal impacts, and proposing policy and technical solutions to promote equity. Structured around three units – science of climate technologies, historical and societal inequities, and policy and solutions – the course integrates research projects, peer review, revision, and writing an op-ed for a non-technical audience. By scaffolding these activities, Garret ensures that students not only learn content but also develop critical thinking, ethical reasoning, and communication skills. The discussion-based design encourages interdisciplinary contributions, helping students leverage their own knowledge while building collective understanding of the societal and environmental justice implications of technology.

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Garret's thoughtful rubric updates, writing-focused instruction, and innovative justice-centered course design demonstrate his commitment to fostering meaningful learning experiences. His contributions enhance multiple courses, and the new MSE curriculum promises to have a lasting impact on students' ability to communicate, reason ethically, and engage with real-world challenges in ways that are equitable and socially responsible.

In sum, Garret embodies the qualities celebrated by the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award: effective, inclusive, student-centered, and justice-centered instruction; dedication to improving student learning and writing; and innovation in curriculum design. I strongly endorse his nomination and am confident that he will continue to make transformative contributions to UCLA's educational mission.

Sincerely,



Regan F. Patterson, Ph.D.
Assistant Professor of Civil and Environmental Engineering